seeking an alliance with the Yuezhi. He returned to Luoyang, the Han capital, after a gap of thirteen years. However, he brought back a wealth of information about countries on China's western periphery, including India. While visiting ancient Bactria (which is modern Afghanistan), he was told about a country called Shendu towards the south-east along a great river; a country which had a warm and humid climate and where wars were fought using elephants. The term Shendu was presumably derived from the river Sindhu, now known as the Indus. It is this river which gave the name by which India became known to the rest of the world. Zhang Qian was also intrigued to find Chinese silk and bamboo items from the province of Sichuan being sold in markets in Bactria. He was told that these items were brought by merchants from Shendu, who acquired them through trade routes in the east. This shows that the earliest contacts between India and China involved the southern and eastern parts of China, which were not yet part of the Middle Kingdom but inhabited by indigenous people, who in turn may have had close trade relations with northern China.

The old trade routes may have been through Yunnan and India's North East. The merchants from India and the region of what is now south and south-west China could have travelled on these routes as well as along ancient maritime routes linking the southern Chinese coast with South-East Asia and India's eastern seaboard. Tamralipti, later Tamluk, was already a well-known port on the Bengal coast during the Mauryan dynasty (322 BCE –185 CE).

In Han chronicles, we find a further and more detailed reference to India and Buddhism. They say that the Han emperor Mingdi (58–75 CE) had a dream in which a golden and resplendent figure with a halo entered the royal palace. His courtiers told him that the figure in his dream was the Buddha, a divine figure from a country to the west. The emperor sent envoys to the west, and legend has it that two Indian monks, Kasyapa Matanga and Dharmaratna, residing in what is present-day Afghanistan, were persuaded to travel to the Han capital Luoyang to expound their faith to the emperor. The two monks carried the Sutra in Forty-two Sections[2] and several Buddhist icons to Luoyang on several white horses. The Han